



■ By Sharda Ugra in Beijing

Travelling to Beijing on the eve of the Olympics, an Indian diplomat said admiringly, "China puts facts on the ground." He was referring to issues other than sport but the message was the same: the Olympics hosts first did, and only then worried about debate. To put India up against China in a sporting context is to invite defeat, most often with democracy cited as the most critical factor stopping India's sports establishment from working like China's does. It is only a part of the truth that seeks to hide Indian sport's biggest weaknesses. Yes, very few Indian parents are willing to send a six-year-old to a sports school on the slim chance of becoming the one success story of every 10. Yet, young Indians in sport have hazardous futures too, caught in a highly-political system that crushes merit with out-dated coaching, poor medical back-up and a culture of carelessness. Even as China pushes its athletes to the edge of their abilities, India's best young sportsmen and women will never know how good they could have been.

India's priorities towards sport have always been muddled, investing in the event rather than the individual. China made its first bid for the Olympics in 1991, after it had won 28 medals in the Seoul Olympics of 1988. In between its application and an inspection visit by the IOC, China finished fourth on the Games medal tally in 1992, winning 54 medals including 16 golds. Its second bid was successful because by then, among other reasons, China had arrived as a world sporting force. India is a long way off from there and needs an internal overhaul before it is to aspire for becoming a true sporting nation.

SCRAP THE TAMASHA

India's Olympic bosses have mastered the art of myth-making, the biggest being that by bidding for and hosting major sporting events, India will suddenly witness a rise in its results. The 2010 Commonwealth Games is the latest of these myths, an

